

Self-portraits

Before the Renaissance, self-portraits were rare. But after Giotto helped artists take a more prominent role in society, they became a way for some to assert their new status. Highly aware of their public image, van Eyck and Dürer made themselves the subject of several self-portraits. From the age of 13 to 28, Dürer produced at least 12 images of himself, including one closely resembling an icon of Christ (see here).

As the centuries passed, artists produced self-portraits for different reasons, often because the sitter comes free, or as self-analysis – as Max Beckmann said: ‘One of my problems is to find the self.’ Murillo, Velázquez and Goya painted perceptive self-portraits, while Rembrandt and Vincent van Gogh are among the most prolific self-portraitists ever. Rembrandt produced over 40, a visual autobiography of his adult life. Van Gogh’s self-portraits served as a form of self-therapy. Between 1886 and 1889, he painted himself 37 times, all with a penetrating look that express his inner anguish.



Van Gogh, *Self-Portrait with Bandaged Ear*, 1889